STRIDE

Athletes are creators with a second payer

Fan subscriptions, sponsorship and the analytics engine that makes the second payer possible. Built for the athletes no agent has ever called.

Jad Zoghaib MSc Business Plan, ESADE · Tutor: Ignacio Gallardo Albajar · October 2026

LIVE DEMO
stride-demo.onrender.com

WHY THIS, FROM ME

I am not researching this market from outside it

ATHLETE

Capped by the Lebanese national rugby team, with international tournament experience. The athletes in my research are people I play with, which is why the conversations were candid rather than performative.

OPERATOR

Four years in management consulting across MENA. Feasibility studies at $5 to 15M, DCF modelling, and an OpEx reorganisation that delivered SAR 650M of capital optimisation.

BUILDER

MSc Business Analytics at ESADE. The deployed product, the analytics engine and the financial model behind this plan are all my own work.

The plan can make claims about the technology that are checkable rather than aspirational, because I wrote it.

WHAT FIVE ATHLETES TOLD ME

€0

CURRENT INCOME FROM THEIR AUDIENCE

Not low. Not inconsistent. Nothing

> People are not going to spend time setting up social media and building followers purely around their sport if nothing comes back.

Rugby league players competing in Spain and Lebanon, and top-ranked Lebanese CrossFit athletes. The founder is capped by the Lebanese national rugby team, which is how this access exists.

THE INEQUITY IS FELT

Influencers producing far less demanding content earn more than competing athletes do

SPONSORSHIP ARRIVES DESPITE THE SPORT

The one athlete who has a sponsor did not get it as a rugby league player

SO THEY STOP BUILDING AN AUDIENCE

Which suppresses the very supply the market is measured on

Primary research, five semi-structured interviews, 2026. Convenience sample, reported as one.

THE MECHANISM

The layer that turns an audience into income was never built for these sports

IN A POPULAR SPORT

An agent takes 10 to 20% of an endorsement to make an introduction. The layer exists, and it is expensive.

IN A NICHE SPORT

There is no agent at all. The athlete's alternative to Stride is not a worse deal. It is no deal.

AND THAT ABSENCE FEEDS ITSELF

01 No route from audience to income

›

02 So no reason to build an audience

›

03 So the market measures smaller than it is

So the market is sized under the very incentives that suppress it. The plan does not claim the expansion, and the honest error direction is understatement.

THE PRODUCT

A creator platform with a sponsorship feature

ATHLETE

SUPPLY, AND THE CONSTRAINT

Connects platforms, passes an admission gate, gets a paid fan page and a place in the sponsor-facing engine.

Pays nothing. No monthly fee, ever

FAN

PAYS FOR ACCESS

Subscribes to an athlete they already follow, at tiers the athlete sets.

15% of fan revenue

SPONSOR

PAYS FOR ATTENTION

Briefs a campaign and gets a ranked shortlist with the arithmetic shown, then measures delivery.

10% of sponsorship

Fan revenue leads and funds the early years. Sponsorship compounds behind it, and the analytics engine earns its keep by making the second payer possible, which a general creator platform cannot do.

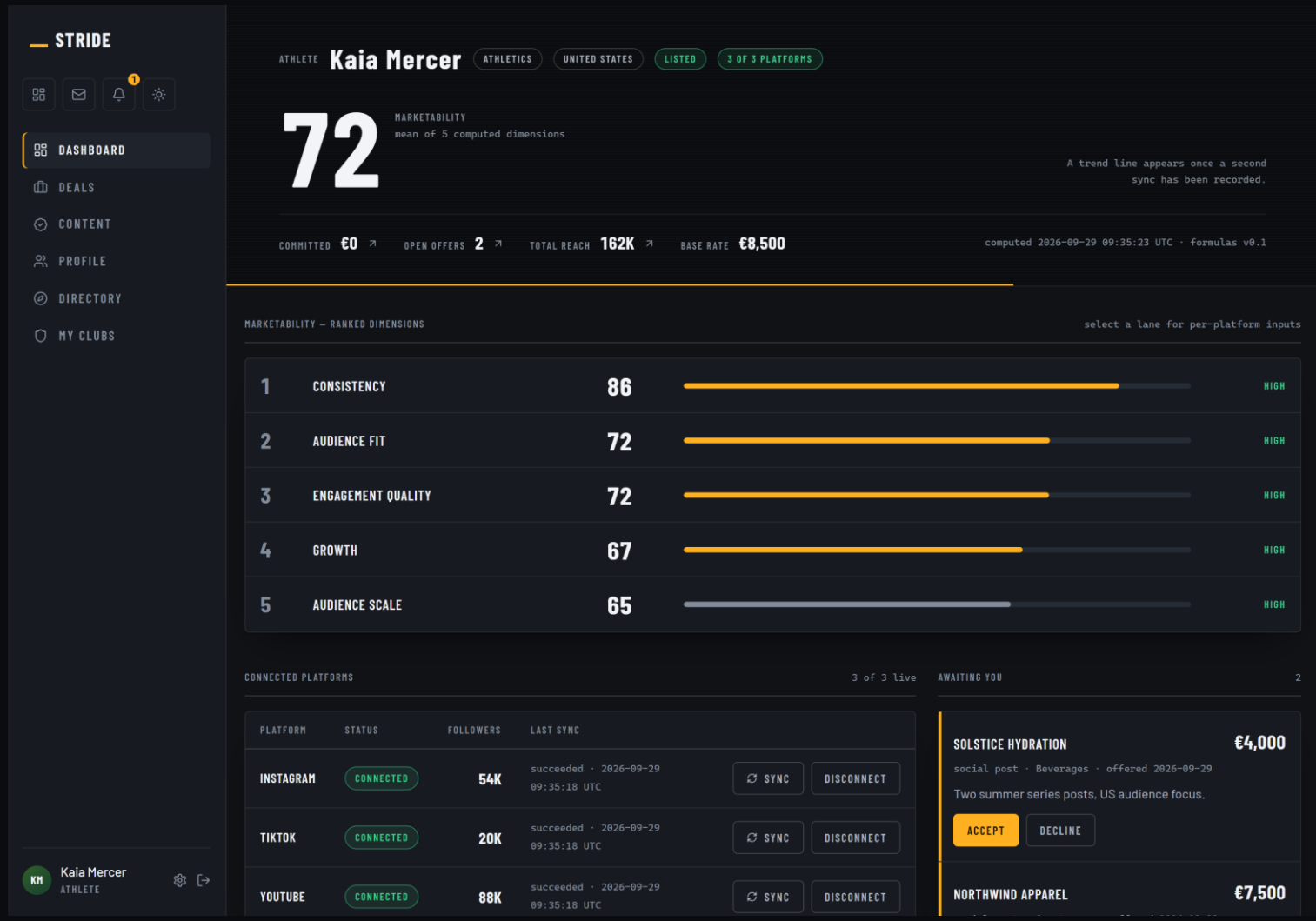
NOT A MOCKUP

It is built, deployed, and you can open it now

- Admission gate with human review
- Versioned marketability scoring
- Explainable campaign matching
- Offers, deals, delivery measurement
- Audit log and a resilience drill
- Tests on two databases in CI

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Fourteen demo accounts. Registration is open.



Athlete dashboard, captured from the running application.

HOW IT WORKS

Four steps, and a rule that holds all four together

01
APPLY

The athlete connects their platforms and applies. Proof is checked automatically, then a person decides. A club can nominate a whole roster as a second route.

02
SCORE

Marketability is computed on eight weighted components, each traceable to the posts behind it, and every score version is kept.

03
MATCH

A sponsor briefs a campaign and receives a ranked shortlist in which every score decomposes: audience fit 72 × 32% = 23.1.

04
DEAL

Offer, acceptance, delivery measured against what was projected. An unmeasured campaign reads as unmeasured, never as zero.

NOTHING SELF-VERIFIES

A club scoring above the verification bar still waits for a human. A rejected proof cannot be cleared by re-submitting the form. That is what a sponsor is actually buying.

PRIMARY RESEARCH

The research changed the product, which is the point of doing it

> Open registration to everyone, but build a filtering mechanism so that not anyone can register as an athlete.

Íñigo Cristóbal Losada, AI Lead at olympics.com, after eleven years at Olympic Broadcasting Services, where he was Broadcaster Services Manager through Tokyo 2020 and Beijing 2022.

WHAT IT CHANGED

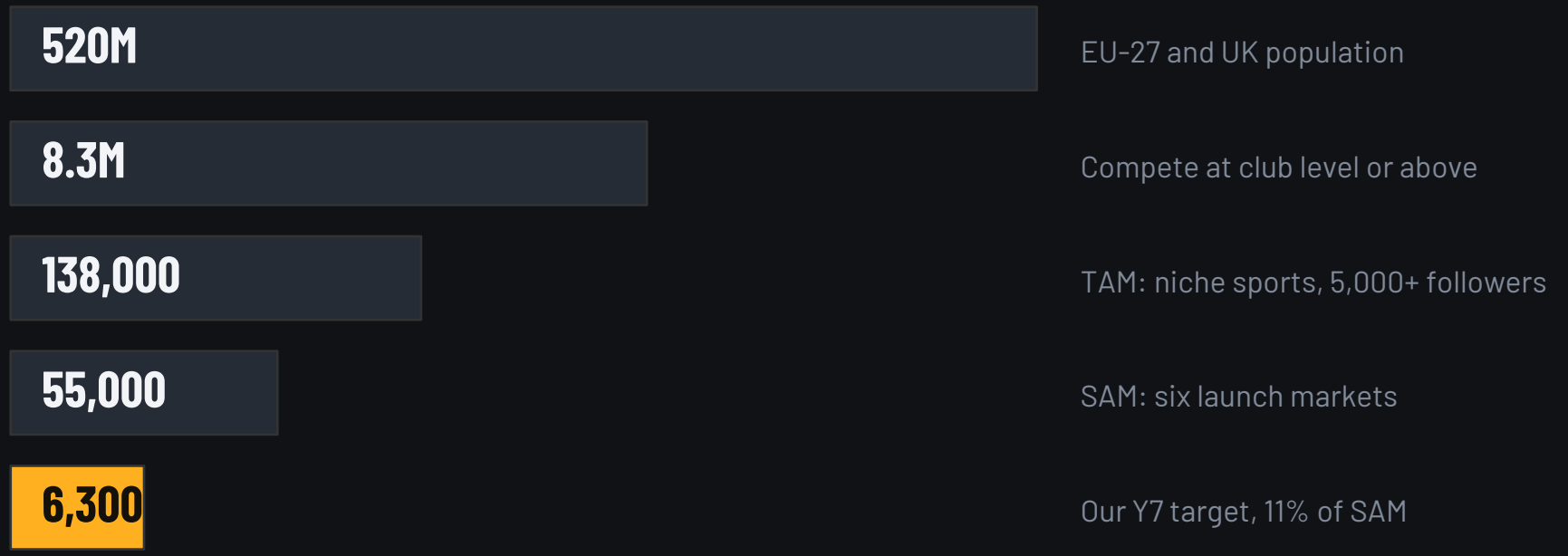
I had pitched it to him as a product for the IOC, open only to Olympic athletes. He rejected that framing outright.

The admission gate exists because of that conversation. It is not a feature that was designed and then justified.

It also settled market entry. An IOC-only product inherits the IOC's athletes: elite, represented, already monetised. The segment with the actual problem sits below that tier.

HOW BIG, BOTTOM UP

A segment nobody measures is a segment nobody has sized a product for



EUROPEAN SPORT SPONSORSHIP

€24.79bn

Growing 5.9% a year

SPAIN, THE FASTEST MAJOR MARKET

+14%

Ahead of the UK and France

None of that top-down figure breaks below the professional tier. There is no published number for sponsorship of individual athletes, so the plan does not divide it by anything. The bottom-up funnel exists because the measured market stops exactly where ours starts.

European Sponsorship Association, 2025, via Statista. Funnel: Eurostat, Eurobarometer 525, and the plan's own Sport Opportunity Index.

THE WEDGE

We start where there is no incumbent, because that is also where the economics are best

NICHE SPORTS

€16

To acquire one athlete in Y1

48%

Of them monetise by Y7

POPULAR SPORTS

€40

To acquire one athlete in Y1

30%

Of them monetise by Y7

Cheaper to acquire, and a larger share of them earn. Nobody is fighting us for a trail runner with 25,000 followers and an inbox of unanswered brand DMs. What we learn there generalises upward. Football does not generalise downward.

Stride financial model, segment assumptions. Acquisition cost rises over the plan as the mix shifts toward popular sports.

FOUR COMPANIES TRIED THIS BEFORE US

All four monetise the brand side only. The fan is not in their model

COMPANY	WHAT IT IS	AGE	PEOPLE	RAISED	WHERE IT GOT TO
Sponsoo	Marketplace, same model	11 yrs	13	€2.17M	Total equity zero
OpenSponsorship	Marketplace, same model	12 yrs	23	€7.6M	Still private
Hookit	Sponsorship data	18 yrs	47	€21.5M	Sold
SponsorUnited	Sponsorship data, enterprise	9 yrs	355	€38.8M	A different business

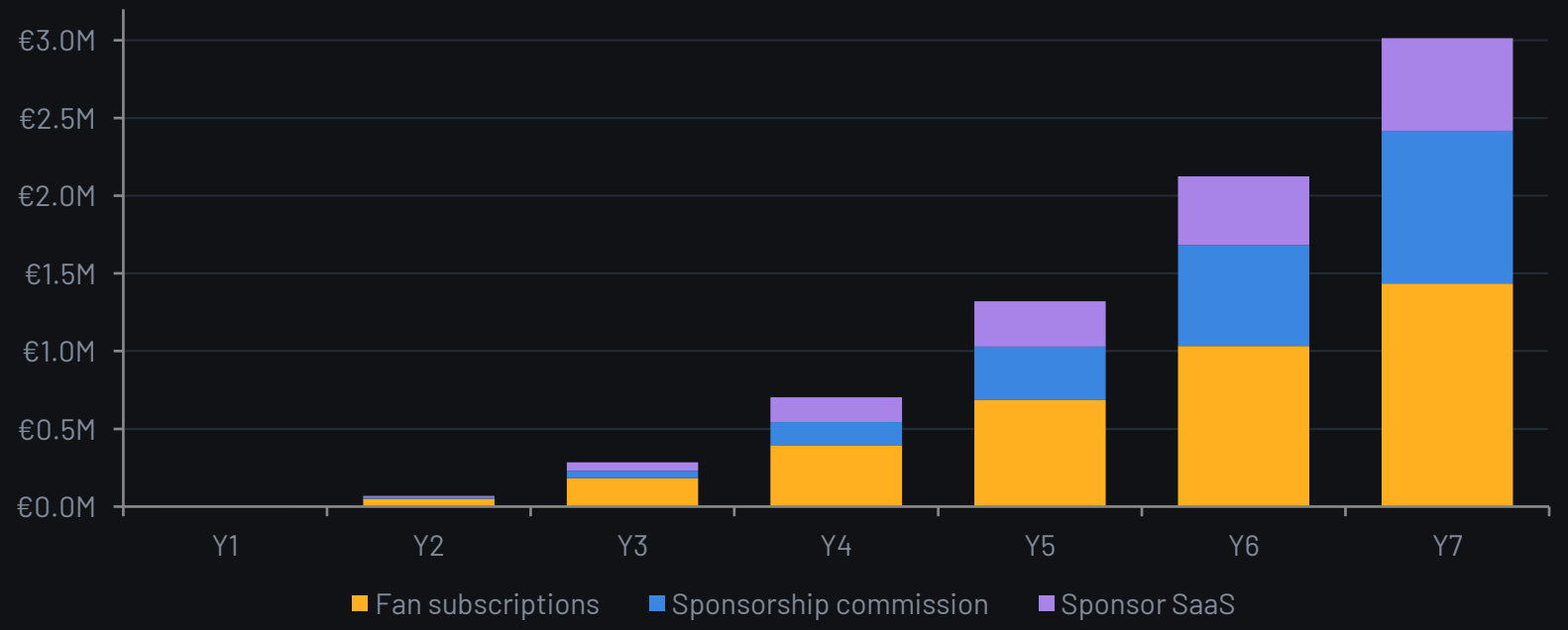
THE SECOND PAYER

Fan subscriptions are 48% of our Y7 revenue, and none of these four has that stream at all. If it works, the economics are not Sponsoo's. If it does not, they are, and this is Sponsoo with eleven fewer years of relationships. The plan prices both cases.

PitchBook company profiles, retrieved 1 October 2026, reported in euros.

REVENUE MODEL

The business changes shape as it grows



Y2

75%

of revenue is fan subscriptions, the year the thesis is tested

Y7

48%

still fan, with sponsorship and SaaS compounding behind it

€3.01M total at Y7

Stride financial model. Y1 to Y7, net revenue after the athlete's share.

GO TO MARKET

Year one, concretely

250

ATHLETES

recruited from 1,250 applications, in two or three niche Spanish sports

20

SPONSOR CONVERSATIONS

which are the first sales as much as the research, closing about 15 deals

1

SALARY

mine, plus a named athlete partner on 5% equity rather than cash

€113k

OF CASH

two thirds of it available as a non-dilutive ENISA loan

THE SEQUENCE IS THE OPPOSITE OF THE OBVIOUS ONE

Build the payment rail and sponsorship billing first, and the fan tier last. Commission is invoiced against a signed deal: it needs no content moderation, no minors safeguarding and no media egress, so it is the cheapest of the three to build and the only one that earns inside the first year.

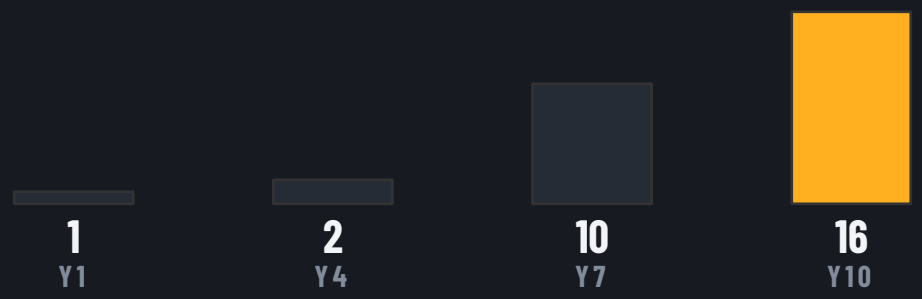
OPERATIONS AND PEOPLE

One human step in the chain, and a team sized to what I can actually run

WHAT IS SUBCONTRACTED

Stripe Connect	Payments, KYC and payouts in 30+ countries
AWS	Compute, database and media processing
Zero-egress CDN	Media delivery, the cost that decides viability

HEADCOUNT



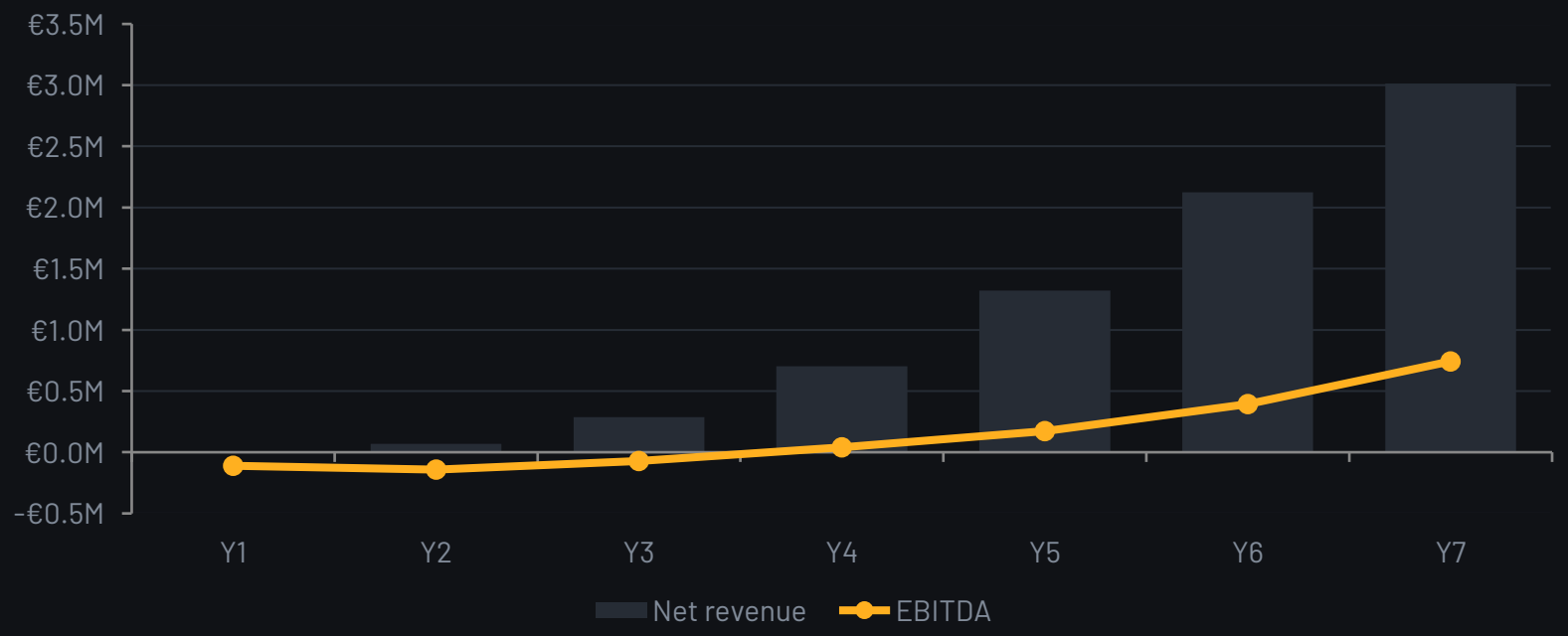
The only human step in the value chain is admission review, and it scales with applications rather than with transactions. That is why sixteen people can run this. Sponsoo took eleven years to reach thirteen, so the comparison is deliberate rather than optimistic.

THE ASSUMPTION I AM MOST EXPOSED ON

€301k of revenue per employee at Y7, against a private B2B SaaS median of €135k. If I am wrong, the first thing to give is headcount, which means slower growth rather than a cash crisis.

FINANCIAL PLAN

Loss-making for four years, and the losses are small



EBITDA POSITIVE

Y4

CASH POSITIVE

Y5

Y7 EBITDA MARGIN

24.7%

Y10 NET REVENUE

€5.25M

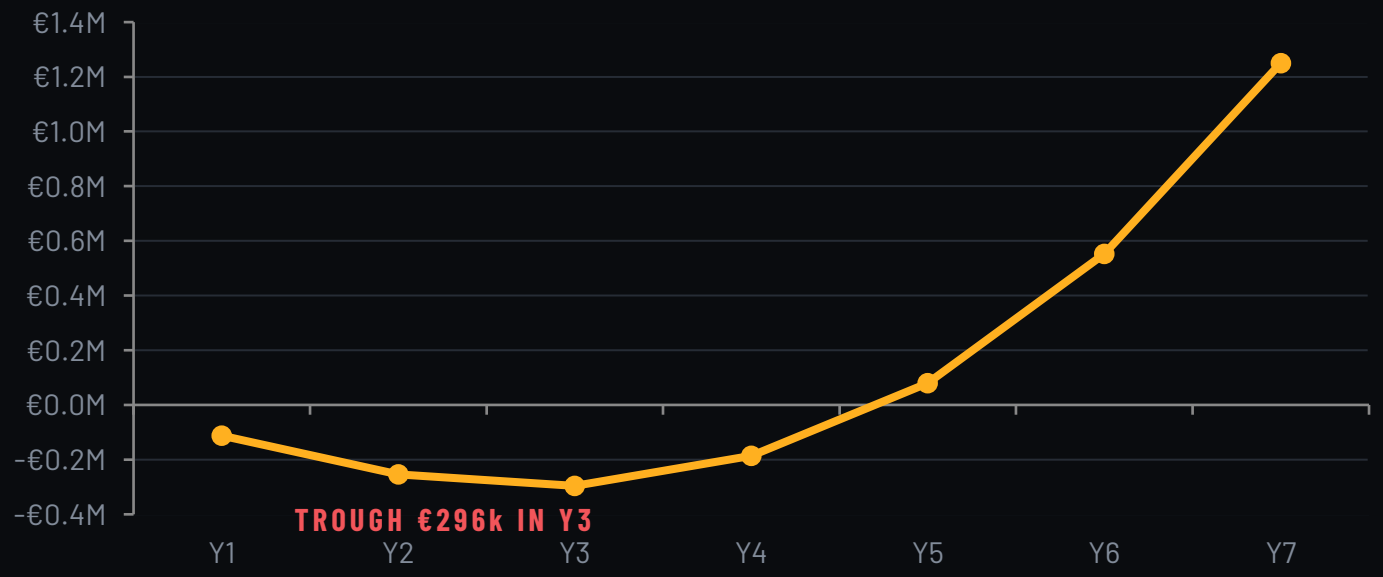
Gross margin climbs from 63% to 70%, not the SaaS 80%, because the payment rail is real.

Stride financial model, base case. Three scenarios are modelled; the pessimistic case still breaks even in Y5.

THE ASK

€150k at €1.8M pre-money

The first of two tranches, and the round that clears the worst point in the cash curve



TOTAL REQUIREMENT
€414k
the €296k trough plus a 40% buffer

NOW
€150k
equity, which also unlocks €75k of non-dilutive ENISA debt

IN Y2
€250k
priced against three months of real subscription revenue, not a promise

Staging it costs about two points of equity and buys the right to price the second tranche on evidence. A plan whose survival does not depend on the next round arriving on schedule is a stronger one to raise against.

ONE ASSUMPTION CARRIES THIS PLAN

Will fans of a semi-professional athlete actually pay?

No interview answers it and no amount of further market sizing can. Only three months of real subscription revenue from one anchor athlete settles it, and that is exactly what the pre-seed buys.

TESTED FOR

€80k and one year

rather than €2.6M and four

IF IT FAILS

A smaller marketplace

viable, but a different company

EVERYTHING ELSE

Already done

built, deployed and demonstrable

STRIDE

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BACKUP

Held for questions

Pricing, scenarios, risk, valuation, dilution and the admission arithmetic.

BACKUP, PRICING

15% sits between the only two published rates in the market

Both ends of the corridor are real competitor economics, derived from filed accounts.

PATREON

10%

all-in, on filed accounts

STRIDE

15%

flat, and no monthly athlete fee

ONLYFANS

20%

and agencies take 20 to 50% on top

At 15% we undercut the nearest comparable for any athlete earning under €1,380 a month, which is the entire long tail we are built for. The decision forfeits €0.5M of Y7 revenue against a 20% take, and buys a pricing argument that survives contact with the exact athlete we target.

Patreon and OnlyFans published terms and filed accounts; agency rates from published commission guides.

BACKUP, SCENARIOS

The plan survives its own pessimistic case

Each case re-runs the whole model on changed drivers rather than adjusting the base result.

CASE	WHAT CHANGES	Y7 REVENUE	Y7 EBITDA	CAPITAL NEED	PROFIT FROM
Pessimistic	Fans/athlete –25%, monetise –20%	**€2.34M**	**€399k**	**€541k**	**Y5**
Base	As modelled	**€3.01M**	**€743k**	**€414k**	**Y4**
Optimistic	Fans/athlete +25%, monetise +20%	**€3.59M**	**€1.04M**	**€347k**	**Y4**

Even the pessimistic case breaks even, one year later and on €541k instead of €414k. The downside here is a slower, smaller company rather than a failed one, and that is the property the staged raise is designed to protect.

Stride financial model, scenario table.

BACKUP, RISK

Eleven risks scored, and one of them is the thesis

Probability × impact, both on a 1 to 5 scale. Nothing is rated more likely than 3.

R1	Fans do not pay for niche-athlete content	3 × 5 = 15	Three months of real revenue from one anchor athlete, before the second tranche
R4	A funded entrant copies the model	3 × 4 = 12	The defence is scoring history and athlete relationships, which take time nobody can buy
R5	Regulatory: DAC7, age assurance, startup law	3 × 4 = 12	Compliance built in rather than retrofitted; reporting is a product feature

A risk map that is evenly scattered has not identified which risk is the real one. R1 is the thesis, and the entire financing structure exists to buy it down cheaply.

BACKUP, VALUATION

Where the €1.8M pre-money comes from

Two methods that disagree, and the disagreement is the honest part.

DCF ENTERPRISE VALUE

€1.23M

25% WACC, 3% terminal growth. Below the pre-money, which is normal for a pre-revenue venture.

COMPARABLE SET

€1.8M

Benchmarked against Sponsoo and OpenSponsorship, the two companies running the same model.

FOUNDER AND TEAM HOLD

65.2%

After both tranches, the optional growth round and a fully topped 10% ESOP.

PRE-SEED

€150k at €1.8M

87.3%

EXTENSION

€250k at €3.5M

81.5%

GROWTH, OPTIONAL

€1.5M at €12M

72.4%

AFTER ESOP

10% pool

65.2%

Founder stake retained through each round

Stride financial model: DCF, comparable transactions from PitchBook, and the dilution waterfall.

BACKUP, THE GATE

What the admission gate actually costs to run

The one human step in the chain, priced from the policy itself rather than assumed.

30.5%

ADMISSION RATE BY Y7

rising from 20% in Y1 as the funnel improves, which makes it a filter rather than a formality

4 min

MEDIAN MANUAL REVIEW

priced at the same loaded salary the people line uses

0.64 FTE

REVIEWER LOAD AT Y10

at 8,500 athletes. Verification is not a money problem at this scale

< 48 h

SERVICE LEVEL

the reason to automate is latency, not cost: a queued athlete is not earning

A club nomination brings a roster of 20 to 40 athletes with the verification problem already solved, and club-nominated applicants are admitted at 45% against 20% direct. That is the channel the growth plan opens at Y3.